



CHAPTER

1

INTRODUCTION



*At last, blessed by our forefathers,
we have reached the end of our journey.*

CAPTAIN ARFAM NAGO OF THE VESSEL *DARSIBAN*, UPON REACHING JUMUAH

At the edge of known space, the survivors of a dying civilization have made their haven. In a hollowed out asteroid they've named Ship City, the brave and the foolish are plotting their next venture into the Great Dark. Arguing about what secrets lay hiding in the dark space; praying for a brighter future; bragging and backstabbing to get onboard the next Greatship expedition into the unknown.

You are one of those fools and heroes: ruin delvers, artifact scavengers or mystery hunters, depending on who you ask. You are the agents of the exclusive Explorers Guild and your job is to go where few others dare. You seek the enigmatic ruins of the Lost Horizon, to solve its mysteries and help your city and your people survive. Ship City is dying but you and your fellow explorers can find a way forward.

This is your mission. This is your destiny. Your creed: explore or perish!

NOW ON KICKSTARTER

This Quickstart is meant to give an opportunity to test *Coriolis: The Great Dark*. This is a cut down version of the upcoming game that will contain a full setting, complete rules and tools for exploring the universe. The adventure in this Quickstart is designed as a straightforward tutorial. Please note that everything in the Quickstart is subject to change: text, art and layout are not final. The crowdfunding campaign for the full game is available on Kickstarter.

INTO THE ABYSS

In *Coriolis: The Great Dark*, you are part of a crew of explorers ready to venture out into this new universe, the Lost Horizon. You have your shuttle, your trusted crewmates and a warding guardian in the form of your bird – a strange alien creature that can help you on your journeys.

You all have your separate backgrounds and homes in the asteroid-metropolis called Ship City. You are employed by a small guild – the Explorers Guild – and are ready to take on the missions they will give you.

Delving into the ruins will bring out the best of you all. You'll have to overcome dangerous environments, face creatures from the dark, and endure the ubiquitous Blight, a plague affecting both mind and body. And other crews of explorers will become your opponents as you vie for the same artifacts and knowledge.

In the metropolis of Ship City, you may take on missions and investigations to help your guild and build your crew's reputation with the other major players of the city.

THE DIASPORA

Once upon a time a disparate group of people left a part of the universe called the Third Horizon – their home. They called themselves the Diaspora and they were fleeing a universe at war, setting their course towards a faint signal from the depths of space. A beacon, they presumed, from the legendary and long lost generation ship Nadir. They set course with the hope that, however futile it seemed, Nadir could somehow bring salvation to them all.

The voyage of the Diaspora was long and arduous and almost tore their fleet apart and it was a considerably diminished fleet that finally arrived at a lone system in unknown space. They named the system Jumuah and rejoiced that their trials were at an end.

And then the signal went silent.

JUMUAH AND A LOST HORIZON

The initial optimism soon gave way to despair. Jumuah was a barren expanse, its vast emptiness broken only by a scattering of asteroids and the presence of two gas giants. The

A ROLEPLAYING GAME ABOUT EXPLORATION AND HOPE

Inspired by 19th-century expeditions, deep-sea diving and pulp archaeology, *Coriolis: The Great Dark* is a roleplaying game about exploration and intrigue where you'll join dangerous expeditions, navigate the Byzantine schemes of Ship City and hunt for the keys that unlock the mystery of this Lost Horizon.

This Quickstart document contains all you need to get started playing *Coriolis: The Great Dark*. If you are

the Gamemaster, welcome! We recommend that you read all the way through at least once. If you are a player, take heed! You do not have to read anything, but for a tour of the setting we advise you to skim through the next few pages. It's important that you do not read the adventure at the end of this booklet or else you will ruin your experience playing it.



remnants of the fleet found sanctuary on a lone asteroid, where they began their search for ways to venture further into this new Horizon. A portal was eventually found, however it was long dead and inactive. There was no way forward from Jumuah and no turning back. The Diaspora had discovered a Lost Horizon.

THE CITY AT THE EDGE OF NOWHERE

What was thought to be a temporary settlement, intended to last just long enough to gather their strength before setting out further into the new horizon, became something else completely. The Diaspora used the remnants of the fleet, anchored to the asteroid, as their primary living quarters and as time went by they started to break down unused and broken ships for constructions on the asteroid. And the settlement grew.

A few generations later, Ship City (or The Ship City of Coriolis the Eternal and Jumuah the First and Last as the tongue-rolling official name is) has become something much

more than the makeshift harbor of the past. Welded and strung together into a tangled labyrinth in and around the asteroid, it has grown in all directions at once, out of necessity and boredom, with whatever was thought needed – from elevators to drug dens. Ship City now is a sight to behold: an asteroid-metropolis of impressive proportions and, although resources are still scarce and individual resolve might falter, a beacon in the dark.

THE RIVER OF STARS

For a long time the people of Ship City thought themselves trapped in the Jumuah system. The dead star portal seemed to make any further exploration impossible. This all changed with the discovery of the Slipstream phenomenon.

Often called the River of the Stars, the Slipstream offers a way of travel far surpassing the speed of traditional space voyages. The true nature and origin of the Slipstream remains a mystery, yet it is the lifeline that sustains both Ship City and the dreams of its people. However, navigating this celestial current comes with its challenges,



necessitating ships that are both stronger and more durable to endure the intense forces at play. Through costly trial and error, the shipwrights eventually managed to find a way to master the stream: the Greatships.

THE GREATSHIPS

Built to withstand the punishment that the unstable Slipstream dishes out, the Greatships are the pride of Ship City. Few in number and enormously expensive to build, Greatships are the largest vessels constructed by the people of

THE DYING CITY

Ship City is the heart of the Diaspora civilization. In fact, it is the only true city in the Lost Horizon. Even so, it is a vibrant metropolis full of life. A paradox, as it is commonly known as 'The Dying City' due to its precarious state. The city spreads out over the rocky surface with the rickety alleys and tunnels of Hull Town, burrows down deep underground in the dizzying drop of the Chasm, where kiteflyers roam, descends through the mist in cable cages where the smell of spices is ever-present. Continue down through the Haze (where one better not dwell) and visit the majestic Cave Gardens where Gardeners tend their precious fields of bloom. Even further is the smog-filled Turbine Halls, where Machinists work their trade. In the City's dusty heart is the Inner Sanctum, a vast and gloomy system of caves where the Coriolites perform their old rituals. Aluminum Bay, at the far end of Ship City, is a bustling harbor filled with crane rats, hull painters and dockworkers all making sure that the Greatships are serviced and ready for the next expedition. Return to the surface and head up the tower of the Astrolaab. Here the Eyes of the Navigators guild peer out into the Great Dark, mulling its mysteries. They might look down on the City, from time to time, and realize what a wonder it really is.

Ship City. Often owned by a consortium of different guilds, these ships require a crew of hundreds and enough supplies to last years.

To this date there have been a dozen so-called great expeditions in the history of the Diaspora and scores of lesser ones. Each expedition is a major undertaking, sponsored by several guilds and often away for months before returning home to port. They seek out valuable resources, stake claims and catalog any ruins encountered. Without the expeditions, Ship City would most likely wither and die.

Greatships provide the people of Ship City with a constant source of strange tales, songs and books. Most know the story of The Great Jumuah, the very first Greatship, but a particularly popular tale is that of the famous Ordana and its discoveries, turned into a score of theater plays and zinti novels. The dark fate of the Hammurabi, lost with all hands on its third voyage down the Slipstream, is spoken of in much more reserved, often whispered, tones.

THE RUINS

The ruins are for obvious reasons at the heart of the mystery surrounding the Lost Horizon and still pose a formidable puzzle. Dotted throughout the system on desolate moons and asteroids, they are, of course, the foremost proof that the Diaspora was not the first to come to this part of the universe.

Beyond that, very little is known about their nature. They come in different varieties, often monumental in size and are largely of chthonian nature. Even though you can find some structures above ground, the way they often expand underground is strange indeed. They all pose different challenges to exploration, from ancient defense systems

to creative constructions that hinder intruders. But the biggest challenge of all is what is called the Blight.

THE BLIGHT

The Blight is the great curse of the Lost Horizon and its manifestations a constant quandary and source of fear for the people of Ship City. This plague appears to have its origin in the ruins. There, it seems, it started and left a warped land full of strange phenomena before crawling out through the system, lessening in effect as it went.

The most apparent effect of the Blight is massive corruption of structures and biology, causing both strange mutations and death. The closer you get to the ruins, the more serious and strange the symptoms get. For explorers, the Blight is a deadly adversary and poses a threat even with all the gear and suits they have developed.

There are also other effects of the Blight that reveal a more mystical dimension to its presence. The eerie dreams reported when travelers come in contact with Blight infestations are just one manifestation of this, but even more obvious are the many uncanny phenomena that occur in places with high Blight concentration.

